



to condemn women in the post-Black Death period. One Italian author wrote that women who survived in Florence became more likely to commit sexual sins, because they had been attended to by men in the plague years. In England, plague widows, who were deemed too quick to move on to new lovers after their husbands died, were the focus of criticism.

A golden age?

Some historians argue that the Black Death led to a golden age for women, particularly in England. In cities, women's economic power increased. Widows were encouraged to continue running their late husbands' businesses. Girls and young women were allowed to take on skilled apprenticeships and join trade guilds, while married women traded as *femmes soles*, a status that gave them

an independent legal and economic identity. However, during the 15th century, once the supply of male labor recovered, many gains made by women were reversed, and by 1500 economic opportunities for women had returned to pre-plague levels.

Other historians argue that women had no golden age of their own at all. Women remained under the legal authority of their male relatives and were generally excluded from civic and political life. In some cases, the plague led fathers to name daughters as their heirs after the death of their sons, but under the legal systems of the time, any inheritance would nonetheless be managed by the daughter's husband. While after the Black Death, those who survived enjoyed the prospect of greater mobility, higher wages, and reduced land prices, this was true for men and women alike.

▲ Afflicted woman

The plague affected men, women, and children alike. Studies suggest that men and women were equally at risk of dying from the disease. This 15th-century fresco from Rhône-Alpes, France, shows a doctor treating a noble lady by lancing a bubo (a swollen lymph gland).